

BUSINESS INSIGHTS REPORT

Sales Performance Analysis

Data Analytics & Business Intelligence — Task 1

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Data Sources: cleaned_sales_data.xlsx | SQL_Queries.sql | Power BI Dashboard (Sales_Performance_Dashboard.pbix)

1. Executive Summary

This report presents a data-driven review of the company's Superstore sales dataset, covering 9,800 order line items placed by 793 unique customers between 2015 and 2018. The dataset was cleaned in Excel, profiled through pivot-table analysis, queried using SQL for aggregation-level validation, and visualised in an interactive Power BI dashboard. The objective is to translate the underlying transactional data into a small set of clear, decision-ready findings for management.

Total recorded sales across the period stand at \$2,261,536.78, an average of \$230.77 per line item. Sales are concentrated in three areas that recur throughout this report: the Office Supplies category, the East and West regions, and the final quarter of each calendar year (September–November). These concentrations point to where the business is already strong and where commercial focus should be reinforced going into the next planning cycle.

Total Sales	\$2,261,536.78
Total Order Line Items	9,800
Unique Customers	793
Average Order Value (per line item)	\$230.77
Highest Single Line-Item Sale	\$22,638.48
Analysis Period	2015 – 2018

2. Regional Performance

Which region generates the highest sales?

The East region leads all four regions with \$679,279.46 in sales (30.0% of the total), narrowly ahead of the West region at \$665,538.79 (29.4%). Central follows at \$577,320.37 (25.5%), while the South region trails noticeably at \$339,398.16 (15.0%) — less than half the value generated by East.

Region	Total Sales (\$)	Share of Total
East	679,279.46	30.0%
West	665,538.79	29.4%
Central	577,320.37	25.5%
South	339,398.16	15.0%

The gap between the top two regions (East, West) and the bottom two (Central, South) is the single most actionable regional signal in the data. East and West together contribute 59.4% of total revenue, while South alone underperforms every other region by a wide margin.

3. Category & Sub-Category Performance

Which category is most profitable in terms of revenue contribution?

Office Supplies is the dominant category, generating \$1,329,693.02 — 58.8% of all sales — more than Furniture and Technology combined. Furniture contributes \$481,172.10 (21.3%) and Technology \$450,671.67 (19.9%), a near-even split between the two smaller categories.

Category	Total Sales (\$)	Share of Total
Office Supplies	1,329,693.02	58.8%
Furniture	481,172.10	21.3%
Technology	450,671.67	19.9%

Top Performing Sub-Categories

Within Office Supplies, Binders (\$355,122.71) and Paper (\$294,666.23) are the two strongest sub-categories in the entire dataset, together outselling the whole Technology category. Phones (\$220,887.77) is the strongest sub-category within Technology, while Furnishings (\$197,812.30) and Chairs (\$155,700.40) anchor the Furniture category.

Sub-Category	Total Sales (\$)
Binders	355,122.71
Paper	294,666.23
Phones	220,887.77
Accessories	198,472.47
Furnishings	197,812.30

4. Customer Segment Analysis

The Consumer segment is the primary revenue driver, contributing \$1,181,308.21 (52.2% of total sales) — more than Corporate and Home Office combined. Corporate customers contribute \$711,646.41 (31.5%), and Home Office is the smallest segment at \$368,582.16 (16.3%).

Segment	Total Sales (\$)	Share of Total
Consumer	1,181,308.21	52.2%
Corporate	711,646.41	31.5%
Home Office	368,582.16	16.3%

5. Shipping Mode Analysis

Standard Class is by far the most-used shipping mode, associated with \$1,399,598.90 in sales (61.9% of the total) — indicating most customers are price- or convenience-sensitive rather than urgency-driven. Same Day shipping accounts for only \$127,021.54 (5.6%), the smallest share of the four modes.

Ship Mode	Total Sales (\$)	Share of Total
Standard Class	1,399,598.90	61.9%
Second Class	432,026.87	19.1%
First Class	302,889.48	13.4%
Same Day	127,021.54	5.6%

6. Sales Trend Analysis

Which month performs best, and is the business growing year over year?

Year-over-Year Growth

Annual sales grew from \$494,524.95 in 2015 to \$749,181.83 in 2018 — a compound annual growth rate of approximately 14.8%. Growth was not linear: sales dipped 5.7% in 2016 before rebounding sharply, up 18.3% in 2017 and a further 35.9% in 2018, the strongest year in the dataset.

Year	Total Sales (\$)	Order Line Items
2015	494,524.95	947 orders
2016	466,152.29	1,019 orders
2017	551,677.71	1,295 orders
2018	749,181.83	1,661 orders

Seasonality (Months Combined Across 2015–2018)

Sales are strongly seasonal. November is the single strongest month, generating \$333,147.97 across the four years, followed by September (\$280,465.44) and December (\$268,776.95). This confirms a pronounced year-end/holiday buying pattern spanning September through December. February is consistently the weakest month at \$86,802.43 — roughly a quarter of November's volume.

Month	Total Sales (\$)
November	333,147.97
September	280,465.44
December	268,776.95
May	232,072.20
March	197,150.63
February (lowest)	86,802.43

7. Top Customers & Top Products

Top 5 Customers by Sales

Customer	Total Sales (\$)
Cindy Schnelling	70,015.48
Katherine Hughes	39,667.66
Caroline Jumper	34,332.33
Lena Cacioppo	28,658.87
Luke Foster	28,638.13

The top 10 customers together contributed \$291,480.44 — about 12.9% of total sales from just 1.3% of the 793-customer base, indicating a meaningful concentration of revenue in a small set of high-value accounts worth targeted account management.

Top 5 Products by Sales

Product	Total Sales (\$)
SanDisk Cruzer 4 GB USB Flash Drive	22,687.73
Anker 24W Portable Micro USB Car Charger	17,517.43
GE 30524EE4	17,499.21
Staple envelope	16,446.79
Atlantic Metals Mobile 5-Shelf Bookcase	12,434.93

8. Key Recommendations for Management

- Prioritise the South region for a focused growth initiative — its sales are less than half of the East region's, representing the clearest untapped opportunity in the current footprint.
- Protect and expand the Office Supplies category, particularly Binders and Paper, which together outsell the entire Technology category; ensure inventory and marketing spend reflect this concentration.
- Plan inventory, staffing, and promotions around the September–November peak, and design targeted campaigns for February–April to smooth the seasonal trough.
- Build a retention programme for the top 10 customers, who deliver almost 13% of revenue from under 2% of the customer base; account-manage this group directly rather than treating it as part of the general segment.
- Continue to lean into Consumer-segment marketing, which drives over half of all sales, while testing bundled offers to grow the smaller Home Office segment.
- Evaluate delivery economics for Standard Class, which carries 62% of order volume — even small efficiency gains here will have an outsized impact on overall margins.

9. Data Notes & Methodology

This analysis is based on the cleaned Superstore-style dataset (cleaned_sales_data.xlsx) after removing duplicates, standardising region/category labels, and correcting date formats, as documented in the accompanying Excel workbook. Pivot tables (Sales by Region, Category, Segment, Month, Top Customers, Top Products) were cross-verified against equivalent GROUP BY aggregation queries in MySQL (SQL_Queries.sql), and the same figures were used to build the interactive Power BI dashboard (Sales_Performance_Dashboard.pbix) with Region, Category, and Date slicers.

The source dataset used for this task contains Sales, Region, Category, Segment, and Ship Mode fields but does not include Profit or Discount columns; profitability and discount-impact figures are therefore intentionally excluded from this report rather than estimated. All monetary figures are stated in USD and rounded to two decimal places to match the source pivot tables.